

# Sensor Technologies for Wastewater Collection Networks: Operating Principles, Field Failure Modes, and Deployment Trade-Offs

## Capstone Research in Wastewater Systems Engineering

Department of Civil, Environmental and Mining Engineering

August 20, 2026

### Abstract

Real-time monitoring of underground wastewater collection networks (WCNs) is essential for mitigating sanitary sewer overflows, managing hydraulic capacity, tracking contaminant discharges, and controlling biogenic sulfuric acid corrosion. However, raw municipal sewage represents a hostile, high-humidity, and geometrically constrained environment that frequently defeats standard instrumentation. This review examines the physical operating principles, real-world failure modes, and practical deployment trade-offs of sensors used across urban wastewater networks. Utility field trials demonstrate that non-contact 77–81 GHz FMCW radar outperforms ultrasonic transducers by eliminating thermal stratification errors (5–12%) and condensation blinding. While continuous level instrumentation is essential at critical trunk manholes, discrete mechanical float and tilt switches provide zero-quiescent-power sentinels that make dense spatial coverage in upstream branches economically viable. For flow quantification, we highlight the physical breakdown of level-to-flow Manning equations during downstream chokes and backwater, demonstrating why simultaneous velocity measurement is required. Finally, we review online water quality probes, optical spectroscopy surrogates for BOD<sub>5</sub>, and liquid-phase bisulfide probes for corrosion control, synthesizing power, maintenance, and communication constraints to guide sensor selection across municipal networks.

**Keywords:** Wastewater monitoring; Level radar; Ultrasonic level; Float switches; Area-velocity flow; Optical spectroscopy; Hydrogen sulfide; Biofouling.

## 1 Introduction and Operational Sewer Realities

---

Wastewater collection networks (WCNs) are sprawling subterranean pipe systems responsible for conveying domestic, commercial, and industrial wastewater to treatment facilities [14, 18]. These networks operate under continuous biological, chemical, and hydraulic stress. Sewers transport a three-phase mixture of liquid effluent, suspended grit, floating fats, oils, and grease (FOG), sanitary wipes, and aggressive headspace gases containing moisture, hydrogen sulfide ( $H_2S$ ), and methane [1, 8].

When pipes choke from grease build-up, root intrusion, structural collapse, or intense storm infiltration, the result is sanitary sewer overflows (SSOs), local surface flooding, and environmental contamination [1]. Historically, water utilities managed networks reactively through customer complaint logs and scheduled visual inspections. Over the past decade, low-power microelectronics, high-frequency radar, optical spectrometry, and low-power wide-area networks (LPWAN) have enabled continuous digital sewer monitoring [6, 8].

However, instrumenting live sewers involves four practical hurdles:

- **Aggressive Atmospheric Chemistry:** Near-saturated relative humidity (95%–100% RH) combined with biogenic sulfuric acid rapidly corrodes unprotected electronics and blinds acoustic and optical sensor faces with condensation [8].
- **Biofouling and Ragging:** Submerged probes accumulate bacterial biofilms within 24–48 hours. Floating grease coats sensing diaphragms, while non-flushable fibrous wipes physically wrap around cables and mounting brackets (ragging) [1, 14].
- **Subterranean Signal Attenuation:** Cast-iron and reinforced concrete manhole covers attenuate radio frequency (RF) transmissions by 20–40 dB, limiting wireless bandwidth and draining battery reserves [12].
- **Hazardous Confined Space Access:** Entering a sewer manhole requires traffic control, atmospheric gas testing, and safety harnesses. Routine manual maintenance is expensive and disruptive, making sensor longevity and self-cleaning mechanisms paramount [18].

This review evaluates the physical operating principles, field resilience, and failure dynamics of sensory hardware across urban wastewater networks. We draw directly on reported utility field trials (such as the Shoalhaven Water radar rollout, Hong Kong flow campaigns, and the UWO urban hydrology laboratory) to evaluate which technologies deliver reliable data in raw sewage and which fail under operational conditions.

## 2 Continuous Level and Depth Sensing Technologies

Continuous depth measurement provides the foundational time series  $h(t)$  needed to track diurnal dry-weather flows, calculate hydraulic surcharge rates ( $\frac{dh}{dt}$ ), and detect emerging downstream restrictions [3, 8]. Four primary continuous level measurement modalities exist in wastewater practice.

### 2.1 Frequency-Modulated Continuous-Wave (FMCW) Radar

Non-contact FMCW radar has become the primary reference technology for sewer depth monitoring. Operating in microwave frequency bands (typically 77–81 GHz), the sensor transmits a continuous electromagnetic chirp whose frequency sweeps linearly over bandwidth  $B$  during sweep duration  $T_{\text{sweep}}$  [8]. The wave reflects off the water surface and mixes with the transmitted signal to create a beat frequency  $f_b$ , from which distance  $d$  is derived:

$$d = \frac{c \cdot f_b \cdot T_{\text{sweep}}}{2 \cdot B} \quad (1)$$

where  $c \approx 3 \times 10^8$  m/s is the speed of light in air. Water depth  $h(t)$  is obtained by subtracting measured distance from the manhole invert elevation:  $h(t) = H_{\text{invert}} - d(t)$ .

**Why radar performs well in sewers:**

- **Narrow beam angles avoid false echoes.** Operating at 77–81 GHz (millimeter-wave band) allows compact antenna lenses to achieve narrow beam divergence angles ( $3^\circ$ – $8^\circ$ ) [8]. In Australian field trials conducted by Drenoyanis et al. [8] across Shoalhaven Water, 80 GHz radar successfully tracked narrow sewer inverts in deep manholes without capturing false echoes from ladder rungs, step irons, or benching walls.
- **Immunity to headspace atmosphere.** Microwave propagation is unaffected by air temperature swings, vertical thermal gradients, dense steam, pressure fluctuations, or methane and  $H_2S$  gases.
- **Strong surface reflection.** Water has a high relative permittivity ( $\epsilon_r \approx 80$ ), giving a sharp reflection boundary even under thin grease or foam layers.

**Operational constraints:** Radar signal processors draw peak currents of 15–35 mA during active sweeps (50–100 mW). To achieve multi-year battery autonomy on primary  $Li - SOCl_2$  packs, radar nodes operate in duty-cycled modes (e.g., waking every 2 to 5 minutes for a 500 ms measurement). Capital costs also remain higher than acoustic or hydrostatic alternatives.

### 2.2 Non-Contact Ultrasonic Level Transducers

Ultrasonic sensors emit high-frequency acoustic bursts (typically 20–200 kHz) from a piezoelectric transducer mounted at the manhole roof, measuring round-trip time-of-flight (ToF)  $\Delta t$ :

$$d = \frac{c_{\text{air}} \cdot \Delta t}{2} \quad (2)$$

While ultrasonic sensors are inexpensive and draw modest power, long-term sewer trials reveal significant environmental failure modes [1, 8]:

- **Thermal stratification errors.** Sound speed in air changes by roughly 0.6 m/s per  $^\circ\text{C}$ . Enclosed manholes develop steep vertical temperature gradients between warm sewage ( $\approx 18$ – $22^\circ\text{C}$ ) and the cold road cover ( $\approx 0$ – $10^\circ\text{C}$ ). Because sound speed varies continuously along the acoustic path, a single temperature sensor on the transducer face produces distance errors between 5% and 12% [8].
- **Condensation blinding and dead-band expansion.** Saturated relative humidity (100% RH) causes moisture droplets to condense directly onto the piezoelectric diaphragm. This moisture dampens oscillation, causing acoustic ringing noise that extends the sensor’s near-field blind zone from 0.15 m to over 0.5 m, blinding the instrument during critical high-water surcharge events [23].
- **Foam absorption.** Biological foam and floating organic scum absorb acoustic compression waves, leading to signal loss and false zero readings.
- **Beam spreading echoes.** Wide beam angles ( $10^\circ$ – $15^\circ$ ) frequently reflect off manhole walls, benching ledges, and ladder rungs, requiring complex echo filtering.

### 2.3 Submersible Hydrostatic Pressure Transducers

Hydrostatic level probes use a piezoresistive silicon strain gauge or ceramic diaphragm submerged at the pipe invert to measure water head:

$$h = \frac{P_{\text{total}} - P_{\text{atm}}}{\rho \cdot g} \quad (3)$$

where  $\rho$  is wastewater density,  $g$  is gravitational acceleration, and  $P_{\text{atm}}$  is atmospheric pressure supplied via a vented capillary tube in the signal cable.

Hydrostatic probes draw minimal electrical power ( $< 15$  mW) and are unaffected by headspace steam or surface foam. However, submerging sensors in raw sewage introduces severe maintenance burdens [8, 14]:

1. **Grease encrustation:** FOG and biofilm coat the sensing diaphragm, dampening pressure transmission and causing progressive calibration drift.
2. **Grit burial:** Heavy inorganic silt settles over invert probes during low nocturnal flows, locking the diaphragm in place.
3. **Capillary vent tube moisture failure:** The atmospheric reference tube easily ingresses humid sewer air if desiccant cartridges are not replaced regularly, causing internal corrosion and permanent sensor failure.

### 2.4 Short-Range Optical Time-of-Flight (ToF) and LiDAR

Optical distance sensors emit pulsed near-infrared laser light ( $\lambda = 850$  nm or  $940$  nm) to measure photon ToF [23]. While micro-LiDAR and ToF sensors demonstrate millimeter accuracy in clean laboratory settings, live sewer trials show that ambient water vapor, fog, and suspended aerosols cause severe optical scattering. Furthermore, splashing sewage coats optical protective lenses with opaque grease films within days, rendering un-wiped optical distance sensors unviable for raw sewage [23].

*Transition to Discrete Sentinels:* While continuous level sensors deliver detailed hydrographs, their capital, power, and maintenance requirements prevent utilities from installing them in every manhole. To achieve broad spatial coverage, utilities deploy discrete binary sentinels.

## 3 Discrete Binary Surcharge Sentinels (Float and Tilt Switches)

---

Discrete sentinels function as binary event triggers. They remain inactive during normal dry-weather flow and signal an alert only when wastewater reaches a predetermined surcharge threshold ( $h \geq h_{\text{alert}}$ ).

### 3.1 Operating Mechanisms

- **Magnetic Reed Float Switches:** A buoyant polypropylene ring slides along a central vertical guide tube containing a hermetically sealed magnetic reed switch. Rising wastewater lifts the float, aligning an internal magnet with the reed switch contacts to close the circuit.
- **Pear-Shaped Rolling-Ball Tilt Switches:** A weighted float hangs vertically in air above normal flow. When rising sewage immerses the float, buoyancy tilts the housing past a critical angle ( $> 15^\circ$ ), causing an internal steel ball to roll across gold-plated microswitch terminals.
- **Zero Quiescent Power Consumption:** Because mechanical dry contacts draw zero current during dry conditions, connected wireless nodes remain in deep sleep, waking via hardware pin interrupts only upon contact closure. This allows battery lifespans of 5 to 10+ years on standard primary cells.
- **Conductivity Pulse Electrodes:** Two metallic electrodes (titanium or 316 stainless steel) are suspended at the alert level. Rising wastewater bridges the electrodes, dropping circuit impedance from  $> 1$  M $\Omega$  to  $< 2$  k $\Omega$ . While devoid of moving parts, electrodes are vulnerable to insulating grease coatings unless periodic high-voltage capacitive discharge pulses are applied to clear grease build-up.

*Transition to Flow Measurement:* Water depth and surcharge alerts indicate how full a pipe is, but evaluating hydraulic capacity, conveyance, and infiltration requires open-channel flow and velocity measurement.

## 4 Open-Channel Flow and Velocity Sensing

---

Quantifying true volumetric discharge ( $Q = A(h) \cdot \bar{v}$ ) in gravity sewers is critical for capacity planning and wet-weather inflow and infiltration (I&I) quantification [1, 3].

Table 1: Operational Comparison: Continuous Level Sensors vs. Discrete Pulse/Float Sentinels.

| Attribute                |                 | Continuous Level Sensors (Radar / Ultrasonic)                    | Discrete Sentinels (Tilt / Float Switch)                      |
|--------------------------|-----------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Output Data</b>       |                 | Continuous depth time series $h(t)$                              | Single-bit event alert (Normal vs. Surcharged)                |
| <b>Trend Tracking</b>    |                 | Captures diurnal hydrographs, baselines, and storm attenuation   | Zero trend visibility below trigger height $h_{\text{alert}}$ |
| <b>Rate-of-Rise</b>      | <b>Tracking</b> | Real-time calculation of $\frac{dh}{dt}$ to predict spill time   | Cannot calculate rate-of-rise; alert occurs at trigger height |
| <b>Power Requirement</b> |                 | Active sweeps $\approx 20\text{--}100$ mW; requires duty cycling | Zero quiescent power; interrupt-driven wake-up                |
| <b>Battery Lifespan</b>  |                 | 2–5 years on $Li-SOCl_2$ cells (5-min duty cycle)                | 5–10+ years on standard primary cells                         |
| <b>Capital</b>           | <b>Cost</b>     | High (\$800 – \$2,500 AUD per node installed)                    | Low (\$100 – \$350 AUD per node installed)                    |
| <b>Primary Modes</b>     | <b>Failure</b>  | False echoes, acoustic refraction, condensation dead bands       | Ragging entanglement around cable; grease sticking            |
| <b>Network Placement</b> |                 | High-priority trunk mains, pump stations, outfalls               | Broad coverage across upstream residential branches           |

#### 4.1 Submerged Area-Velocity (AV) Ultrasonic Doppler Probes

Submerged AV probes combine a piezoresistive depth sensor with acoustic Doppler transceivers mounted at the pipe invert.

- **Acoustic Doppler Shift:** The sensor emits ultrasonic beams ( $f_0 \approx 500$  kHz–1 MHz) into the oncoming stream. Suspended particulate matter and micro-bubbles reflect sound back with a frequency shift  $\Delta f$ :

$$v_{\text{particle}} = \frac{c_{\text{fluid}} \cdot \Delta f}{2f_0 \cos \theta} \quad (4)$$

where  $\theta$  is the beam inclination angle and  $c_{\text{fluid}} \approx 1480$  m/s is sound speed in sewage.

- **Velocity Profiling:** Pulsed Acoustic Doppler Velocity Profilers (ADVP) gate returning echoes in discrete time windows, measuring velocity across multiple vertical layers to determine true mean cross-sectional velocity  $\bar{v}$ .
- **Field Failure Vulnerabilities:** Submerged AV probes are prone to ragging (fibrous wipes wrapping around the probe wedge), silt burial during low night flows, and signal loss in clear water [1].

#### 4.2 Non-Contact Dual-Radar (Level + Surface Velocity)

To avoid probe submergence and ragging, contactless monitoring stations combine an FMCW level radar with a 24 GHz planar microwave Doppler radar pointed at the water surface ( $\theta \approx 45^\circ$ ) [1, 3].

- **Surface-to-Mean Velocity Conversion:** Microwave Doppler measures surface velocity  $v_s$ . Cross-sectional mean velocity  $\bar{v}$  is estimated using empirical conversion factors:

$$\bar{v} = k \cdot v_s \quad (\text{where } k \approx 0.85 \text{ to } 0.90) \quad (5)$$

- **Hydrodynamic Breakdown:** Field trials by Alshami et al. [1] and Blumensaat et al. [3] show that the index factor  $k$  is not constant. Under backwater conditions, standing surface waves, or heavy grease scum, surface velocity decouples from underlying flow, creating discharge errors exceeding 30–50%.

#### 4.3 Why Level-to-Flow Manning Equations Fail in Practice

A frequent shortcut in sewer monitoring is estimating flow  $Q$  purely from water depth  $h(t)$  using Manning’s open-channel equation:

$$Q = \frac{1}{n} A(h) R_h(h)^{2/3} S_0^{1/2} \quad (6)$$

where  $n$  is Manning’s roughness,  $A(h)$  is wetted area,  $R_h(h)$  is hydraulic radius, and  $S_0$  is pipe slope.

**The physical failure mechanism:** Manning’s equation strictly assumes **\*\*steady, uniform flow\*\*** where the hydraulic friction slope equals the physical bed slope ( $S_f = S_0$ ). In real sewer networks, flow is rarely uniform:

1. **Downstream Blockages and Chokes:** When a partial blockage forms downstream, water level rises ( $h \uparrow$ ) while velocity drops ( $v \downarrow$ ). Manning’s equation interprets the rising depth as an increase in flow ( $Q \uparrow$ ), reporting an imaginary surge in conveyance when the pipe is actually backing up [1].
2. **Backwater and Sump Inundation:** Upstream backwater from pump station wet wells or high river levels flattens the hydraulic gradient ( $S_f \ll S_0$ ), producing discharge overestimations up to 200%.
3. **Variable Wall Roughness:** Slime biofilms and sediment beds alter effective roughness  $n$  over time ( $n = 0.011\text{--}0.018$ ). Accurate flow measurement in non-uniform reaches requires simultaneous measurement of both depth and velocity.

*Transition to Water Quality:* Beyond hydraulic conveyance, smart sewer networks increasingly require online characterization of the wastewater chemical and biological matrix.

## 5 Online Water Quality and Chemical Sensing

### 5.1 Basic Physicochemical Probes: EC, pH, ORP, and DO

- **Electrical Conductivity (EC):** Toroidal inductive (electrodeless) conductivity probes use two encapsulated wire toroids inside a polymer casing. An alternating primary magnetic field induces a current in the surrounding fluid, which induces a secondary signal in the receiving toroid. Because the coils are sealed in chemically inert PVDF or PEEK, inductive probes avoid electrode fouling, scaling, and polarization [14]. Baseline EC ( $\approx 800\text{--}1500 \mu\text{S/cm}$ ) drops during rainwater dilution ( $< 200 \mu\text{S/cm}$ ), while sudden spikes ( $> 4000 \mu\text{S/cm}$ ) pinpoint industrial brine dumping or coastal saltwater intrusion [20].
- **pH and Oxidation-Reduction Potential (ORP):** Measured potentiometrically using a glass-bulb hydrogen-ion-selective membrane paired with an  $\text{Ag}/\text{AgCl}$  reference electrode. In raw sewage, reference junctions suffer rapid poisoning when dissolved sulfide ( $\text{S}^{2-}$ ) reacts with silver chloride to form insoluble silver sulfide ( $\text{Ag}_2\text{S}$ ), causing severe potential drift ( $> 50 \text{ mV/week}$ ) [11]. Solid-state polymer electrolyte junctions with double-junction barriers extend maintenance intervals from weekly to monthly. ORP values below  $-150$  to  $-300 \text{ mV}$  indicate septic anaerobic conditions favorable to sulfide production [5].
- **Optical Luminescent Dissolved Oxygen (LDO):** Operates via phosphorescence phase-shift quenching. Collisions with dissolved molecular oxygen ( $\text{O}_2$ ) quench ruthenium or platinum complexes immobilized in an oxygen-permeable cap. Field trials by Helm et al. [9] demonstrated that optical luminescent sensors have complete immunity to  $\text{H}_2\text{S}$  poisoning, consume zero oxygen (operating reliably in static zero-flow manholes), and maintain calibration for 6–12 months, outperforming amperometric Clark cells.
- **Turbidity and Total Suspended Solids (TSS):** Quantified optically via nephelometric light scattering ( $\lambda = 860 \text{ nm}$ , ISO 7027). Motorized wipers are mandatory in raw sewage; un-wiped optical faces become occluded by biofilms and grease within 24–48 hours [10, 11].
- **Nutrient Ion-Selective Electrodes (ISEs):** PVC membranes doped with nonactin measure ammonium ( $\text{NH}_4^+$ ). Potassium ions ( $\text{K}^+$ ) present cross-interference due to similar ionic radii ( $r_{\text{K}^+} \approx 133 \text{ pm}$  vs.  $r_{\text{NH}_4^+} \approx 143 \text{ pm}$ ), requiring secondary potassium ISEs for mathematical compensation [22].

### 5.2 Optical Spectroscopy for Rapid Organic Load Tracking

Standard laboratory measurements of organic load ( $\text{BOD}_5$ , COD, and TOC) require a 5-day incubation or 2-hour chemical digestion. In-situ optical spectroscopy provides instantaneous, reagent-free surrogates [4, 10, 14]:

- **UV-Vis Spectrophotometry (200–750 nm):** In-situ spectrometer probes measure multi-wavelength absorbance across a narrow gap (1–2 mm in raw sewage). Dissolved organics with conjugated double bonds absorb in the UV range ( $\lambda = 254 \text{ nm}$ ), nitrate absorbs in the deep UV ( $\lambda = 210\text{--}220 \text{ nm}$ ), and particulate solids cause visible scattering (400–750 nm). Chemometric deconvolution (PLSR) converts raw absorption spectra into continuous proxies for COD, TOC,  $\text{NO}_3^-$ , and TSS [10].
- **2D-Fluorescence (EEM) Spectroscopy:** Measures fluorescence across excitation-emission matrix coordinates. Protein-like fluorophores (**Tryptophan-like Peak T**,  $\lambda_{\text{ex}}/\lambda_{\text{em}} \approx 280/350 \text{ nm}$ ) correlate closely ( $R^2 > 0.85\text{--}0.95$ ) with readily biodegradable biochemical oxygen demand ( $\text{BOD}_5$ ) [4]. Peak T provides a 5-second optical proxy for  $\text{BOD}_5$ , eliminating the 5-day laboratory delay for treatment plant influent control.

### 5.3 Microbial Fuel Cell (MFC) Biosensors

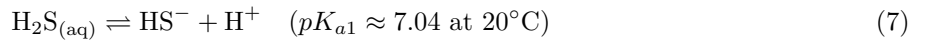
MFC biosensors use electrochemically active bacteria (anodophilic exoelectrogens, such as *Geobacter sulfurreducens*) immobilized as an anaerobic biofilm on a carbon anode [21]. Microorganisms metabolize organic matter in the wastewater, transferring electrons directly to the anode to generate a current proportional to BOD ( $I_{\text{cell}} \propto \text{BOD}$ ). While directly measuring biologically assimilable organics, MFC sensors experience saturation at high BOD ( $> 300 \text{ mg/L}$ ) and response time lags (10–30 minutes) governed by microbial metabolic rates [21].

*Transition to Corrosion Dynamics:* Among chemical processes in sewers, sulfide generation is the primary cause of asset degradation through biogenic crown corrosion.

## 6 Hydrogen Sulfide ( $H_2S$ ) and Biogenic Crown Corrosion

Biogenic sulfuric acid corrosion in concrete sewer crowns is driven by hydrogen sulfide emissions [15, 16].

- **Aqueous Sulfide Speciation and Headspace Stripping:** Under anaerobic conditions in submerged biofilms and force mains, sulfate-reducing bacteria (SRB) reduce sulfate to dissolved sulfide ( $S^{2-}$ ,  $HS^-$ ). Liquid-phase speciation is governed by pH:



At typical wastewater pH  $\approx 6.8$ – $7.2$ , approximately 40%–60% of total dissolved sulfide exists as molecular  $H_2S_{(\text{aq})}$ , which strips across the liquid-gas interface into the headspace:

$$r_{\text{emission}} = K_L a \cdot \left( [H_2S_{(\text{aq})}] - \frac{C_{\text{gas}}}{H} \right) \quad (8)$$

where  $K_L a$  is the mass transfer coefficient (greatly increased by drop manholes and turbulent bends) and  $H$  is Henry’s law constant. Headspace  $H_2S$  is oxidized by aerobic bacteria on moist concrete walls to sulfuric acid ( $H_2SO_4$ ), degrading concrete crowns at rates up to 5–10 mm/year [16].

- **Headspace Gas Sensors:** Amperometric electrochemical gas cells provide sub-ppm sensitivity (0.1–500 ppm) at micro-watt power. However, condensing humidity (100% RH) blinds gas membranes with moisture droplets, while exposure to severe sulfide spikes ( $> 500 \text{ ppm}$ ) poisons the electrolyte, causing baseline drift [15].
- **Liquid-Phase In-Situ UV Bisulfide Probes:** Submerged UV spectrometer probes measure bisulfide ion absorption in the deep UV band ( $\lambda \approx 230 \text{ nm}$ ). Despot et al. [7] demonstrated that submerged UV probes with automated wipers can operate in raw sewers for over six months, providing direct feedforward chemical dosing control (e.g., iron salts or oxygen injection) that reduced chemical consumption by 35% compared to retrospective gas-phase monitoring.

*Transition to Pipe Condition:* Beyond liquid-phase and headspace monitoring, utilities require physical methods to screen pipe structural integrity and identify localized blockages.

## 7 Pipe Condition, Blockage, and Structural Screening

### 7.1 Acoustic Pulse Reflectometry

Acoustic pulse reflectometry provides rapid, non-invasive condition screening for sewer conduits [2, 19, 24]. An acoustic transceiver mounted in a manhole transmits an acoustic pulse (100 Hz–5 kHz) down the pipe headspace. When the acoustic wave encounters a change in cross-sectional area—such as a silt deposit, grease accumulation, tree root intrusion, or lateral fracture—a reflection returns to a microphone array [2]:

$$R = \frac{Z_2 - Z_1}{Z_2 + Z_1} = \frac{A_1 - A_2}{A_1 + A_2} \quad (9)$$

where  $Z = \frac{\rho c}{A}$  is acoustic impedance, and  $A_1, A_2$  are pipe headspace areas before and at the obstruction. Field evaluations by Bin Ali et al. [2] and See et al. [19] demonstrate that acoustic reflectometry can screen up to 100 meters of pipe in under 30 seconds from a single manhole, identifying  $> 10\%$  cross-sectional blockages without deploying a crawler.



## 7.2 Distributed Fiber-Optic Sensing (DTS/DAS)

Fiber-optic sensing cables installed along the crown or invert turn the optical fiber into a continuous sensor array [17]:

- **Distributed Temperature Sensing (DTS):** Uses Raman backscattering optical time-domain reflectometry (OTDR) to measure temperature profiles every 1 meter over 10–30 km cables. Localized thermal anomalies (0.5°C shifts) pinpoint lateral illicit connections and cold groundwater infiltration plumes [17].
- **Distributed Acoustic Sensing (DAS):** Uses Rayleigh coherent optical time-domain reflectometry ( $\phi$ -OTDR) to detect acoustic vibrations from bedload sediment transport, gas bubbling, and structural cracking.

## 7.3 CCTV Inspection and Automated Computer Vision

Closed-Circuit Television (CCTV) robotic crawlers equipped with high-definition cameras capture internal pipe imagery. Convolutional neural networks (CNNs) automatically segment cracks, displaced joints, root intrusions, and grease accumulation from video logs [13]. However, CCTV remains a periodic inspection method (conducted every 5–10 years) and cannot provide real-time hydraulic alert capability.

*Transition to Deployment Engineering:* Even the most capable sensors will fail if telemetry, biofouling, and power constraints are not addressed.

# 8 Environmental Resilience, Telemetry, and Power Budgets

---

## 8.1 Biofouling and Grease Mitigation

Bacterial colonization forms thick biofilms in raw sewage within 48 hours, while FOG precipitates onto surfaces to create sticky grease crusts.

- **Non-Contact Sensors:** FMCW radar and acoustic sensors mounted in the manhole chimney are physically decoupled from the effluent, avoiding direct biofouling. Splashing during severe storms can deposit grease on lenses, requiring annual visual checks [8].
- **Submerged Probes:** Hydrostatic, AV Doppler, and optical probes require automated mechanical wipers, ultrasonic cleaning horns, or pressurized air purges to prevent measurement drift [11, 14].

## 8.2 Subterranean Telemetry and Radio Propagation

Transmitting data from underground manholes to cloud platforms is constrained by RF physics [8, 12]:

- **LoRaWAN (868 / 915 MHz):** Long-range, low-power spread spectrum modulation achieves high penetration through concrete shafts, reaching 3–8 km line-of-sight from manhole chimneys to gateway towers [8].
- **Cellular IoT (NB-IoT / LTE-M):** Licensed cellular bands (700–900 MHz) provide narrow carrier bandwidths with +20 dB link margin over legacy GSM.
- **Manhole Cover Attenuation:** Solid cast-iron covers reflect > 99% of RF energy (20–40 dB loss). Practical solutions include mounting antennas directly beneath composite non-metallic covers, using external low-profile puck antennas embedded in road asphalt, or suspending dipole antennas in the chimney neck [8].

## 8.3 Battery Life and Adaptive Sampling

Long-term deployment mandates 3–7 years of maintenance-free operation on internal  $Li - SOCl_2$  battery packs (e.g., 19 Ah at 3.6 V). Battery life is extended using adaptive duty cycling: nodes maintain long sampling intervals (30–60 minutes) during steady dry-weather flows, dynamically accelerating to 1-minute intervals once water level rate-of-rise exceeds a threshold ( $\frac{dh}{dt} > \theta_{rise}$ ) during storm events.

# 9 Comprehensive Comparative Synthesis

---

Tables 2 and 3 present a comparative synthesis across the physical, hydraulic, chemical, optical, and gas sensing modalities evaluated in this review.

Table 2: Comparison of Physical, Hydraulic, Level, Flow, and Structural Sensors in Wastewater Systems.

| Sensor Modality                       | Physical Principle                           | Target Parameter                   | Power Demand                            | Primary Failure Modes in Wastewater                                              | Maintenance Requirements                         | Cost Tier              |
|---------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|------------------------|
| <b>FMCW Radar (77–81 GHz)</b>         | Microwave beat frequency ( $f_b \propto d$ ) | Continuous depth $h(t)$            | Medium ( $\approx 50$ – $100$ mW sweep) | False reflections in narrow shafts; grease crust bridging                        | Non-contact; annual optical check; 5+ yr battery | High (\$1.2k–\$2.5k)   |
| <b>Ultrasonic Level (20–200 kHz)</b>  | Acoustic transit-time ToF                    | Continuous depth $h(t)$            | Low–Med ( $\approx 20$ – $50$ mW)       | Thermal stratification refraction (5–12% error); face condensation; foam damping | Bi-monthly lens wipe; temperature calibration    | Medium (\$400–\$900)   |
| <b>Hydrostatic Pressure Probe</b>     | Submerged piezoresistive diaphragm           | Water column head $h(t)$           | Very Low ( $\approx 5$ – $15$ mW)       | Diaphragm FOG encrustation; sediment burial; capillary moisture ingress          | Monthly physical cleaning; desiccant replacement | Low–Med (\$300–\$700)  |
| <b>Mechanical Float / Tilt Switch</b> | Microswitch / rolling ball circuit closure   | Binary surge alert                 | Ultra-Low (Zero quiescent sleep)        | Ragging entanglement around cable; grease ball sticking                          | Semi-annual mechanical free-movement test        | Very Low (\$100–\$250) |
| <b>Submerged AV Doppler Flow</b>      | Acoustic Doppler backscatter + depth         | Velocity $\bar{v}$ + depth $h$     | Medium ( $\approx 80$ – $150$ mW)       | Silt burial; ragging entanglement; signal loss in clear water                    | Monthly confined entry; rag removal              | High (\$2.5k–\$5k)     |
| <b>Contactless Dual-Radar Flow</b>    | FMCW level + microwave Doppler               | Surface velocity $v_s$ + depth $h$ | Med–High ( $\approx 100$ – $300$ mW)    | Standing waves; $k$ -factor breakdown under backwater                            | Quarterly beam alignment; velocity calibration   | High (\$3k–\$6k)       |
| <b>Acoustic Pulse Reflectometry</b>   | Acoustic waveguide impedance change          | Pipe blockage, silt, cracks        | Low ( $\approx 30$ – $60$ mW)           | Lateral junction echo interference; high ambient acoustic noise                  | Non-contact; annual transceiver check            | Med (\$1.5k–\$3.5k)    |

## 10 Conclusion

This review has evaluated the operational physics, failure dynamics, and practical trade-offs of sensor technologies across municipal wastewater collection networks. Five core findings emerge:

- Continuous Level Sensing:** High-frequency (77–81 GHz) FMCW millimeter-wave radar provides the most resilient non-contact depth measurement, eliminating the thermal stratification errors (5–12%) and condensation dead-band expansion that impair ultrasonic transducers in deep, humid manholes.
- Role of Discrete Sentinels:** Mechanical float and tilt switches provide an ultra-low-power, zero-quiescent-current solution with 5–10+ year battery lifespans, making dense spatial sentinel coverage across upstream residential branches economically viable.
- Flow Measurement Limitations:** Manning’s equation level-to-flow conversions fail during downstream blockages and backwater events. Reliable discharge quantification requires simultaneous velocity measurement via submerged AV Doppler or non-contact surface microwave Doppler.
- Rapid Optical Water Quality Surrogacy:** UV-Vis spectrophotometry and 2D-fluorescence EEM spectroscopy (targeting tryptophan-like Peak T) deliver rapid, reagent-free proxies for COD, TOC, and 5-day BOD<sub>5</sub>, bypassing traditional 5-day laboratory incubation delays.
- Corrosion Monitoring:** Preliminary utility trials show that liquid-phase in-situ UV bisulfide ( $HS^-$ ) probes with automated wipers can enable proactive chemical dosing control before toxic  $H_2S$  gas strips into the sewer headspace.



Table 3: Comparison of Physicochemical, Optical, Biological, and Gas-Phase Sensors in Wastewater Systems.

| Sensor Modality                        | Operating Principle                               | Target Analyte                       | Power Demand                   | Deployment | Primary Failure Modes in Wastewater                                | Maintenance Requirements                       | Cost Tier                |
|----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|--------------------------------|------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|--------------------------|
| <b>Inductive Toroidal EC</b>           | Electrodeless dual-toroid magnetic induction      | Total dissolved ions ( $\sigma$ )    | Low ( $\approx 20$ –50 mW)     |            | Heavy scaling encrustation; temperature sensor failure             | Monthly wipe; 5+ yr lifespan; low drift        | Medium (\$600–\$1.2k)    |
| <b>Potentiometric pH / ORP</b>         | Glass bulb + $Ag/AgCl$ reference potential        | Acidity, redox potential             | Low ( $\approx 10$ –30 mW)     |            | Reference junction $Ag_2S$ sulfide poisoning; glass grease coating | Bi-weekly cleaning; monthly buffer calibration | Low–Med (\$400–\$800)    |
| <b>Optical Luminescent DO</b>          | Phase-shift phosphorescence quenching             | Dissolved oxygen ( $O_2$ )           | Low ( $\approx 15$ –40 mW)     |            | Biofilm growth on luminophore cap; photo-bleaching                 | Monthly cap wipe; annual cap replacement       | Med–High (\$1.2k–\$2.5k) |
| <b>UV-Vis Spectrophotometer</b>        | Multi-wavelength absorbance (200–750 nm)          | COD, $NO_3^-$ , TOC, TSS             | High ( $\approx 1$ –5 W scan)  |            | Optical window biofouling; matrix turbidity scattering; lamp aging | Automated wiper mandatory; monthly cleaning    | Very High (\$8k–\$25k)   |
| <b>2D-Fluorescence (EEM)</b>           | Fluorophore intensity (Peak T / Peak C)           | Rapid BOD <sub>5</sub> surrogate     | High ( $\approx 2$ –8 W)       |            | Inner-filter quenching; window biofouling; matrix shifts           | Frequent optical cleaning; site calibration    | Very High (\$15k–\$40k)  |
| <b>MFC Biosensor (BOD)</b>             | Microbial extracellular electron transfer current | Biodegradable organic BOD            | Low–Med ( $\approx 10$ –30 mW) |            | Biofilm saturation ( $> 300$ mg/L); metabolic lag (10–30 min)      | Monthly nutrient flush; active research        | Med–High (\$2k–\$5k)     |
| <b>Headspace Gas <math>H_2S</math></b> | Amperometric oxidation at gas electrode           | Gas-phase $H_2S$ (0.1–500 ppm)       | Very Low ( $\approx 5$ –20 mW) |            | Electrolyte dry-out; condensation blinding; high-ppm poisoning     | Quarterly recalibration; annual replacement    | Medium (\$600–\$1.5k)    |
| <b>Liquid Bisulfide Probe</b>          | In-situ UV absorbance at $\lambda \approx 230$ nm | Dissolved $HS^-$ for chemical dosing | Med–High ( $\approx 1$ –3 W)   |            | Severe window biofouling; wastewater color interference            | Automated wiper mandatory; monthly check       | High (\$5k–\$12k)        |

## References

- [1] Ahmad Alshami, Mohamed Elsayed, Ehab Ali, Abdelrahman E. E. Eltoukhy, and Tarek Zayed. Monitoring blockage and overflow events in small-sized sewer network using contactless flow sensors in Hong Kong: Problems, causes, and proposed solution. *IEEE Access*, 11:87131–87149, 2023.
- [2] M. T. Bin Ali, Kirill V. Horoshenkov, and Simon J. Tait. Rapid detection of sewer defects and blockages using acoustic-based instrumentation. *Water Science and Technology*, 64(8):1700–1707, 2011.
- [3] Frank Blumensaat et al. The UWO dataset – long-term observations from a full-scale field laboratory to better understand urban hydrology at small spatio-temporal scales. *Earth System Science Data*, 18:5187–5208, 2026.
- [4] E. M. Carstea, John Bridgeman, Andy Baker, and Darren M. Reynolds. Fluorescence spectroscopy for wastewater monitoring: A review. *Water Research*, 95:205–219, 2016.
- [5] Lluís Corominas et al. Profiling wastewater characteristics in intra-urban catchments using online monitoring stations. *Water Science and Technology*, 89(6):1412–1426, 2024.
- [6] Everton T. de Camargo et al. Low-cost water quality sensors for IoT: A systematic review. *Sensors*, 23(9):4424, 2023.
- [7] Danijel Despot, Mario Pacheco Fernández, and Matthias Barjenbruch. Comparison of online sensors for liquid phase hydrogen sulphide monitoring in sewer systems. *Water*, 13(13):1876, 2021.

- [8] Arthur Drenoyanis, Raad Raad, I. Wady, and C. Krogh. Implementation of an IoT based radar sensor network for wastewater management. *Sensors*, 19(2):254, 2019.
- [9] I. Helm et al. Comparative validation of amperometric and optical analyzers of dissolved oxygen: a case study. *Environmental Monitoring and Assessment*, 190:313, 2018.
- [10] Mathieu Lepot, Andres Torres, Thomas Hofer, et al. Calibration of UV/Vis spectrophotometers: A review and comparison of different methods to estimate TSS and total and dissolved COD concentrations in sewers, WWTPs and rivers. *Water Research*, 101:519–534, 2016.
- [11] Tao Li, M. Winnel, H. Lin, et al. A reliable sewage quality abnormal event monitoring system. *Water Research*, 121:248–257, 2017.
- [12] Gustavo A. Lopez-Ramirez and Alejandro Aragon-Zavala. Wireless sensor networks for water quality monitoring: A comprehensive review. *IEEE Access*, 11:95120–95142, 2023.
- [13] Saber Moradi, Tarek Zayed, and Farzad Golkhoo. Review on computer aided sewer pipeline defect detection and condition assessment. *Infrastructures*, 4(1):10, 2019.
- [14] Alessandro Moretti, Hugo L. Ivan, and Jan Skvaril. A review of the state-of-the-art wastewater quality characterization and measurement technologies. is the shift to real-time monitoring nowadays feasible? *Journal of Water Process Engineering*, 60:105061, 2024.
- [15] Mario Pacheco Fernández, Danijel Despot, and Matthias Barjenbruch. Comparison of H<sub>2</sub>S gas sensors: A sensor management procedure for sewer monitoring. *Sustainability*, 13(19):10779, 2021.
- [16] Sudhir Kumar Pandey, Ki-Hyun Kim, and Kea-Tiong Tang. A review of sensor-based methods for monitoring hydrogen sulfide. *TrAC Trends in Analytical Chemistry*, 32:87–99, 2012.
- [17] Janna Prisutova, Anton Krynkina, Simon Tait, and Kirill Horoshenkov. Use of fibre-optic sensors for pipe condition and hydraulics measurements: A review. *CivilEng*, 3(1):85–113, 2022.
- [18] Ben Zion Rousso and Yang Gong. Smart sewers in practice: a systematic review of instrumentation, applications and pathways to adoption for sustainable urban systems. *Journal of Environmental Management*, 401:128922, 2026.
- [19] Chan H. See, Kirill V. Horoshenkov, M. T. Bin Ali, and Simon J. Tait. An acoustic sensor for combined sewer overflow screen condition monitoring in a drainage infrastructure. *Sensors*, 21(2):404, 2021.
- [20] Ben Shi, S. Catsamas, Ana Deletic, et al. Illicit discharge detection in stormwater drains using an Arduino-based low-cost sensor network. *Water Science and Technology*, 85(5):1372–1383, 2022.
- [21] Jayesh M. Sonawane, Chigozie I. Ezugwu, and Prakash C. Ghosh. Microbial fuel cell-based biological oxygen demand sensors for monitoring wastewater: State-of-the-art and practical applications. *ACS Sensors*, 5(8):2297–2316, 2020.
- [22] Ee X. Tan, Anthony Anastasi, and Sudesh Chandra. Electrochemical detection of nitrate, nitrite and ammonium for on-site water quality monitoring. *Current Opinion in Electrochemistry*, 32:100926, 2022.
- [23] Y. Utepov, A. Neftissov, T. Mkilima, et al. Prototyping an integrated IoT-based real-time sewer monitoring system using low-power sensors. *Eastern-European Journal of Enterprise Technologies*, 3(5/123):6–23, 2023.
- [24] Yang Yu, A. Safari, X. Niu, Bruce Drinkwater, and Kirill V. Horoshenkov. Acoustic and ultrasonic techniques for defect detection and condition monitoring in water and sewerage pipes: A review. *Applied Acoustics*, 183:108282, 2021.